AGAINST All Odds

The Afghan documentary filmmaker **Sahra Mani** talks about the making of *Bread & Roses* and having Hollywood A-lister Jennifer Lawrence as a producer


AFP

In the weeks and months following the fall of Kabul on August 15, 2021, documentary filmmaker Sahra Mani started to receive daily vlogs from women in her home country of Afghanistan. This was real-time footage filmed on phones by "educated and working women who believed that they can and should be equal partners in the future of our country". "Instead, they had started losing all their rights, from education to working to even stepping out of their homes," says Mani. Around the same time, the filmmaker received an e-mail from Excellent Cadaver, a production company headed by Oscar-winner Jennifer Lawrence and her producing partner Justine Ciarrocchi, offering their support in case she wanted to make a film about women in Afghanistan. This is how the documentary, *Bread & Roses*, which premiered at Cannes in 2023 and is now on Apple TV+, was born.

Filmed in the Afghan languages of Dari and Pashto, *Bread & Roses* follows three fearless women—newly engaged dentist Zahra Mohammadi, activist Taranom Seyedi and Sharifa Movahidzadeh, a government official—in the early months of the Taliban regime as women were systematically stripped of all their rights.

Most recently, women have been banned from receiving



INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL ROTTERDAM, on from Jan. 30 to Feb. 9, will showcase 15 Indian films

IN THE GLOBAL LIMELIGHT

Indian cinema is well represented at the upcoming International Film Festival Rotterdam

What a time for Indian cinema! In the wake of Payal Kapadia's global acclaim for *All We Imagine as Light*! Fifteen Indian films, including global premieres, find space in the 2025 International Film Festival Rotterdam (Jan. 30 to Feb. 9).

Kapadia's film is part of the Limelight section, which brings together last year's highlights and the most anticipated films of 2025. Also in the section are two Tamil films—Ram's *Fly Away*, which follows a debt-stricken man and his pampered son on a countryside motorcycle trip, and a director's cut of Pa. Ranjith's *Thangalaan*, a British India-set tale of caste, sorcery and imperialism.

In the Tiger competition section, meant for upcoming global talent, is Varsha Bharath's *Bad Girl*. The Tamil comedy follows a young woman's journey of finding the perfect man while fighting social mores and strict parents. The Big Screen competition features Suman Mukhopadhyay's